While the opposition parties have roundly criticized it as a disastrous failure, spokespersons of the government have tried to showcase the demonetization exercise as a grand success that will have manifold long-term benefits for the Indian economy.

Stepping back and rising above politics, the basic issue confronting each one of us who cares about the future of India, is what that future holds for our children and grandchildren.

Prime Minister Modi received a record mandate in 2014 as the people of India voted for 'Achhe Din'. More jobs, greater ease of doing business, more transparency, more opportunities, more prosperity, and more wealth – this was the vision. His speeches went to the heart of the dreams and aspirations of every Indian, and this is why India voted for him.

I believe that our country is poised at a critical point in history. In the next few decades, we can create the enabling circumstances to empower our people to rise from poverty into prosperity. If we can capitalize on the demographic dividend of our millennial generation, and harness the talent and entrepreneurial skills of our people, this could be the dawn of a golden age for India.

However, this is also a period fraught with great challenges.

Every day, almost 33,000 young Indians enter the workforce. Many of them are ill-equipped with the skills needed for the twenty-first century. Growing unemployment, low economic growth, and declining investment levels are leading to a situation where these young people are not being provided with opportunities for gainful employment. As traditional occupations like farming are no longer able to provide a viable livelihood or satisfy their aspirations, protests are growing across the country by farmers, demanding higher prices for their produce and reservations for their children. The increasing incidents of violence by aimless and unemployed youngsters against 'others', be they women, Dalits, or members of minority communities, point to a future where our demographic dividend could well turn into a demographic disaster.